ground realities had required military operations beyond the LOC, we would have seriously considered it. We never thought atomic weapons would be used, even if we had decided to cross the LOC."[72]

Tactical and diplomatic calculations, then, rather than Pakistani nuclear weapons, were primarily responsible for the Indian refusal to cross the LOC during the Kargil conflict. This does not mean that Pakistan's nuclear capacity was entirely irrelevant to Indian decision-making. Malik concedes that Pakistani nuclear weapons led the Indians to rule out full-scale conventional war with Pakistan. However, as he explains, nuclear weapons were "not decisive" in India's refusal to violate the LOC, since the Indians did not believe that crossing the line would trigger nuclear escalation.[73] Thus, nuclear weapons did have a limited stabilizing effect on the conduct of the Kargil conflict; the danger of a Pakistani nuclear response would have prevented India from deliberately launching a full-scale war against Pakistan. However, Pakistani nuclear deterrence did not prevent India from violating the line of control. Indian leaders' decision against crossing the LOC turned mainly on nonnuclear considerations.[74] And Pakistani nuclear weapons facilitated the outbreak of the Kargil conflict in the first place.

It is important to stress that although India and Pakistan managed to avoid both a nuclear and an all-out conventional confrontation at Kargil, such an outcome was hardly a foregone conclusion. Had the Indians not prevailed from behind the LOC, they probably would have crossed the line and escalated the conflict. We cannot know where such actions would have led. Although the Indians would not have deliberately threatened Pakistan with catastrophic defeat, the Pakistanis could have perceived rapid Indian conventional gains as an existential threat, particularly if they endangered Pakistan's nuclear command and control capabilities. The Pakistanis could have responded with a large-scale conventional or even a nuclear attack.[75] Kargil's relatively restrained outcome belies the conflict's considerable danger.

In the late 1990s, South Asia experienced its first war in twenty-eight years. Between December 2001 and October 2002, it experienced the largest ever Indo-Pakistani militarized standoff. The